



City College

of San Fernando, Pampanga

GENERAL EDUCATION

UNDERSTANDING THE SELF

STUDY GUIDE FOR MODULE NO. 1

CHAPTER I: THE SELF FROM VARIOUS PERSPECTIVES

A. PHILOSOPHY



MODULE OVERVIEW

This module seeks to understand the construct of the self from various disciplinary perspectives: philosophy, sociology, anthropology and psychology – as well as the more traditional division between the East and the West – each seeking to provide answers to the difficult but essential questions of “What is the self?” And raising, among others, the question “Is there even such a construct of the self?”



MODULE LEARNING OBJECTIVES

1. Discuss the different representations and conceptualizations of the self from the various disciplinary perspectives;
2. Examine the different influences, factors and forces that shape the self;
3. Compare and contrast how the self has been represented across the different disciplines and perspectives;
4. Demonstrate critical and reflective thought in analyzing the development of one's self and identity by developing a theory of the self.



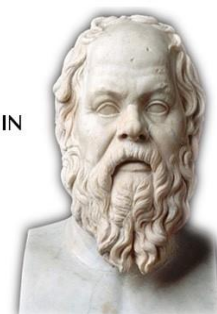
LEARNING CONTENTS

I. Socrates, Plato, Augustine

In the recent time, the philosophy and teachings of **Socrates** is being discussed and even debated by even the most distant philosophers. His way of understanding a subject through posing a question and answer which eventually leads to further questions is known today as *Socratic Method*.

The phrase “Know thyself”, as associated with Socrates, is a motto inscribed on the frontispiece of the Temple of Delphi. Thus, by its epistemology, it is an ancient greeting of the highly civilized Greek which would mean gaining information of one's self that are measurable. But for the philosophers, the assertion of knowing thyself, that is imperative and a requirement by nature, indicates that man should stand and live according to his nature. In the words of Socrates, we all have the knowledge of our self and we just have to have wisdom or learn to recollect.

THE ONLY TRUE WISDOM IS IN
KNOWING YOU KNOW
NOTHING
- SOCRATES



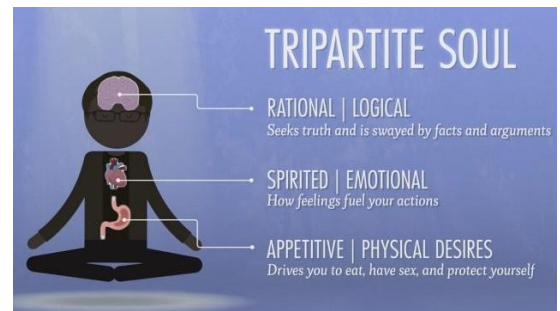
To attain the knowledge of knowing one's self, one may have dialogue between the soul and itself, or between a teacher and a student. Socrates questions for the reason he knows nothing, and that he knows that he knows nothing, and has nothing to learn (*“I Know that I Do Not Know”*). And by such, discovery knowledge about the self may foster.

For Socrates, the true task of the philosophers is to know oneself for *“An unexamined life is not worth living.”*

Socrates also believes on the dualism of reality, that the nature of man is comprising with the

a *Body* which is imperfect and changeable and *Soul* that is perfect and unchanging.

Plato supported the idea of his teacher, Socrates, but although being influenced by his teacher, Plato did have a difficulty viewing the “soul” as an immortal entity that is unchanging. Thus, Plato added that there indeed a tripartite soul: the Appetitive, Spirited, and the Mind (Nuos). The *appetitive soul* includes one’s desire, pleasure, physical satisfaction, comfort, while *spirited soul* includes the basic human emotions like love, anger, ambitions, etc. The *mind* on the other hand is considered to be the most superior of the three components and the super power that controls the affairs of the self. And a person becomes just and virtuous when these three components are in harmony with each other.



Like Plato, **St. Augustine of Hippo** also adapted both Socrates and Plato’s vision of the dualism of reality in the medieval period, the *Physical Realm* represented by our body that is imperfect, and the *Ideal Realm*. As a converted Christian, St. Augustine adapted the metaphysics of Christian belief to explain his philosophy. If from Plato, the immortal soul achieves eternal realm through intellectual enlightenment, for St. Augustine, the immortal soul strives to achieve God through faith and reason and our physical world is a proving ground for our eternal destinies.

To add, St. Augustine posited that the development of the self-starts when one self-presentation and self-realization, that is being aware of the kind of person one is.

II. Descartes, Locke, Hume, Kant

As the father of modern philosophy, it is no doubt that **Rene Descartes** recognizes the significant questions about the human existence of the early philosophers. Hence, as a scientist, Descartes based his discussion and knowledge of human existence through rational inquiry and real-world experimentation.

In the best-known work of Descartes, *Meditation of First Philosophy*, he discussed that it is only in doubting the knowledge one obtained and collecting a true and well supported beliefs through empirical evidences can one achieved a well reason conclusion. A conclusion that is genuinely by one’s self and not by other people. In his statement “*for once in your life, doubt, as far as possible, all things*”.

With Descartes quest for true knowledge, he became famous to his principle “*I Think Therefore, I Am*”.

John Locke, on the other hand opposes the idea that reason is the only way of looking at the self. For him the **self is comparable to an empty space** and such empty space will be provided with sense data, through the encountered **experiences** of an individual. The process of reflection and analysis undergone by these sense data will lead to what is known as sense perception.

Challenging Locke, **David Hume** positioned that knowledge can only be possible if it is sensed and experienced. Our ideas regarding the self are based on *impressions* that are temporary, thus, for him, there is no persisting self.

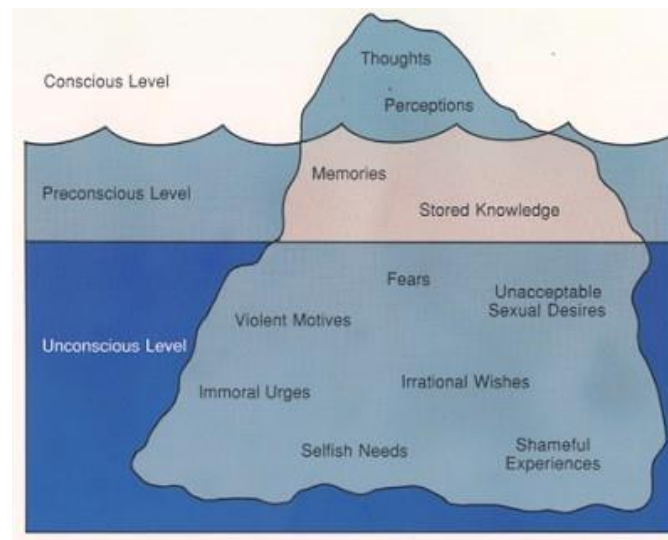
The veracity of Hume regarding the idea of the self as originating to one’s sensation and perception is being recognized by **Immanuel Kant**, hence, his philosophy regarding the

Transcendental Unity of Apperception discussed that the self is also outside the body and goes beyond the limit of what we are experiencing. Indeed, *ideas* which are bundles of impressions according to Hume, is not being disregarded by Kant. But even if ideas are temporary, there is still what we call "*space and time*" that will remain and will be part of one's self.

III. Freud, Ryle, Churchland, and Merleau-Ponty

Sigmund Freud regarded the self as the "I" that ordinarily constitute both the mental and physical actions. Also, the "**I**" is a **product of multiple interactions, systems, and schemes** as it undergoes the process of continual change. It in such premise that one does have difficulty providing a concrete answer to the question "Who Am I?" as our moral judgment, inner sensation, perception, and bodily movement changes. To further understand the complexity of the "I", **two models** were proposed: the *Topographical Model* that divides the "I" into Conscious or that which we are aware of, and the *Structural Model* or that which represented by the **three different dimensions of the self**: id, ego, and super ego. While the *id* is considered to be the instinctive dimension of the self and the core of an individual's being the *super ego* on the other hand acts as an individual's conscience that controls the id, synthesizing the morals, values, and system in society.

Freud's Three Layers of the Self



In the Concept of the Mind of **Gibert Ryle**, he postulated that one can never find the **thinking I** since it is just "**a ghost in the machine**" and the **mind is never separate from the body**. For us to understand the self-overt behavior should be manifested. Thus, the statement "I act therefore I am" and "you are what you do" are based on the manifested one's physical activities and behavior which means that the kind of mind an individual possessed depends on how it is expressed through words and action.

THE DOGMA OF THE GHOST IN THE MACHINE...MAINTAINS THAT THERE EXIST BOTH BODIES AND MINDS; THAT THERE OCCUR PHYSICAL PROCESSES AND MENTAL PROCESSES; THAT THERE ARE MECHANICAL CAUSES OF CORPOREAL MOVEMENTS AND MENTAL CAUSES OF CORPOREAL MOVEMENTS.

- GILBERT RYLE -

Related to what Ryle positioned on his Concept of the Mind, couples **Paul and Patricia Churchland** proposed that to understand the self, one must consider studying the neurological aspect of the self, "**Eliminative Materialism**", where activities happening with an individual is explained through understanding the existing condition of the brain and how it work. To do this, one may opt to undergo MRI or CT scan.

Churchland stresses that all a person has is the brain, and so if the brain is gone, there is no self. The physical brain and not the imaginary mind, gives people the sense of self. The mind does not really exist because it cannot be experienced by the senses.

The **Phenomenology of Perception** of **Maurice Merleau-Ponty** has raised the idea that the body and mind are intertwined and cannot be separated from each other as all experiences are embodied. An individual's body will serve as the individual's opening towards that person's existence to the world. The philosophy of Merleau-Ponty is based on Wolfgang Kohler and Kurt Kofka's **Gestalt Psychology**, and **Neurobiology** as well.

Merleau-Ponty notes that everything that people are aware of is contained within the consciousness. Consciousness is a dynamic form responsible for actively structuring conscious ideas and physical behavior. He is convinced that consciousness, the world and the human body are intricately intertwined in perceiving the world.

SUMMARY

The self as defined by the different philosophers as connected primarily into one's consciousness or at least with the faculty of rational choice. For the ancient and medieval philosopher, reality is in fact dualistic, although in the medieval period, philosophers had introduced understanding the self through empirical evidences, it is through the contemporary philosophers that the investigation of the self-became truly scientific



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